

THE TEA BREAK

With the Industrial Revolution in full swing in the late 19th century, factory workers had to endure long shifts. Employers began providing free tea to their workers for mid-morning and afternoon breaks; this custom came to be known as the “tea break.” In time, household servants began to be given tea allowances.



TEA BLOCK

Before WWII, Chinese and Japanese green teas accounted for 40 percent of all tea consumed in North America.



WORLD WAR II

Tea played a key role in boosting British morale during WWII. Although tea was rationed to 2oz (56g) per person, per week for civilians, extra was given to troops and those working in the emergency services.

As shipping lanes to North America were blocked as a result of the war, only black tea could be shipped across the Atlantic. By the end of the war, the North Americans had stopped drinking green tea altogether, and would only take it up again much later.

1908

Thomas Sullivan, a New York tea merchant, sends samples of tea to customers in silk pouches, inadvertently inventing the tea bag

1939–1945

World War II sees tea rationed and important trade routes for tea blocked

1960S–TODAY

Tea popularity continues to rise, making tea the second most widely consumed drink in the world, after water

1910

Indonesia begins to cultivate tea

1920

Tea bags are developed for the commercial market

1957

The Rotorvane machine is invented, making tea production more efficient

AFTERNOON TEA

By the end of the 19th century, afternoon tea had become a ritual in England, both with the aristocracy and with the middle classes.

Ladies entertained their close friends for tea at home wearing specially made tea gowns, which were informal flowing dresses worn without a corset. Tea shops opened in towns and became the meeting place for the early suffragette movement.



TEA PLANTATION

Tea flourishes in Munnar in the southern state of Kerala at elevations of 5,200ft (1,600m).